ethnic society, rather like India today. The Rig Vedic people could well have been part of this bubbling mix.

Let us turn now to the geographical event on which the archaeology and the texts categorically agree—the drying up of the Saraswati. Whichever way one looks at it, one cannot escape the conclusion that the drying up of this river was a major event in the evolution of India's civilization.

WHAT HAPPENED TO THE SARASWATI?

The identification of the Saraswati with the Ghaggar is not new. A number of nineteenth-century British explorers and cartographers identified the dry riverbed with the river mentioned in old texts and legends. However, with modern satellite data, the matter can now be said to be settled. As we have seen, the Rig Veda talks incessantly about the great Saraswati river, echoed by the later Vedas. However, texts of the next generation repeatedly mention how the Saraswati dried up. The *Panchavamsa Brahmana* tells us that the river disappeared into the desert. There are many legends and folk tales about how the river dried up or sank underground. What was the cause of its downfall?

As already mentioned, physical surveys and satellite photographs confirm that the Sutlej and the Yamuna were once tributaries of the Saraswati. This would have made the Saraswati a very impressive river with a flow that was larger than that of the Indus and the Ganga. It is not surprising that so many early Harappan settlements were centred around this great river. Unfortunately, the river appears to have lost the Yamuna, perhaps due to a major tectonic event. We have seen how the Himalayas are notoriously unstable and prone to major earthquakes. The earthquakes of 2600 BC may have been especially large but there would have been other tectonics movements as well. The loss of the Yamuna was not the end of the Saraswati's misfortunes. It then lost the Sutlej, its other major tributary, to the Indus. The Sutlej is a moody river and has had many channels in its past. Its ancient name Shatadru literally means 'Of a Hundred Channels'. At